

FATIGUE & DAMAGE TOLERANCE PLANNING FOR HYBRID eVTOL STRUCTURES

Why powered-lift airframes run two certification philosophies at once —
and five planning principles that keep programs off the critical path

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Executive Summary

Nearly every eVTOL and powered-lift aircraft in development today is a hybrid structure: a composite airframe carried on metallic fittings, joints, and dynamic components. That single design fact has a certification consequence most programs discover late — the aircraft must satisfy two different fatigue and damage tolerance philosophies at the same time, and the two must agree at every interface where composite meets metal.

This paper describes the hybrid-structure problem in terms of the governing rotorcraft rules — 14 CFR §29.571 for metallic structure and §29.573 for composite structure — and lays out five planning principles, drawn from three decades of rotorcraft and tiltrotor certification work including the AW609, the first civil tiltrotor certification effort. The common thread: the decisions that determine F&DT outcomes are made at preliminary design, long before any compliance report is written. Programs that treat F&DT as a late-program documentation activity retrofit it at enormous cost. Programs that seat it at concept keep it off the critical path.

The Hybrid-Structure Problem

A composite fuselage does not eliminate safe-life thinking — it relocates it. The fittings that carry the wing, the joints that transfer rotor or proprotor loads, the dynamic components in the drive and actuation systems: these remain metallic on virtually every powered-lift configuration flying or in development. The result is one aircraft governed by two distinct damage philosophies:

Metallic structure (§29.571) is substantiated through crack initiation and growth. The structure must sustain limit load with damage present after a demonstrated growth interval, and the Airworthiness Limitations Section (ALS) publishes inspection thresholds, repeat intervals, and retirement times derived from that growth behavior.

Composite structure (§29.573) is substantiated through a no-growth demonstration. Damage at the threshold of detectability — barely visible impact damage (BVID) — must not grow under repeated loads, and the structure must carry ultimate load with BVID present and limit load with visible damage. Environmental knockdowns and material variability are substantiated per program rather than drawn from long-established metallic specs.

Neither philosophy is harder than the other. The difficulty is the interface: every joint where composite skin meets metallic fitting is a place where two substantiation logics, two strength floors, and two inspection programs must be shown to work together. The FAA will ask how they interface at every one of those joints. The programs that struggle are the ones answering that question for the first time at certification review.

Dimension	Metallic — §29.571	Composite — §29.573
Philosophy	Crack initiation + growth	No-growth demonstration
Strength floor	Limit load after demonstrated damage growth	Ultimate load with BVID; limit load with visible damage
Variability basis	Established material specifications	Substantiated per program
ALS output	Inspections + retirement times	Inspections + replacement times

Table 1 — One aircraft, two rules. A hybrid airframe runs both, and they must agree at every interface.

Five Planning Principles

1. Sequence the FEM strategy: global model before detailed model

The global finite element model (GFEM) answers the questions that change the airplane — load paths, internal loads, stiffness targets — and it iterates in hours. The detailed model (DFEM) answers a certification question — does this specific joint or fitting hold positive margin — and it iterates in weeks. Teams that build detail first, on the theory that they will need it for cert anyway, routinely lose months when the configuration moves; six months of detailed modeling discarded at a single design review is not a hypothetical. The pipeline that works is GFEM through the design loops, configuration freeze, then DFEM for compliance. Everything left of the freeze is cheap to change; everything right of it is expensive.

2. Treat the certification basis as an engineering deliverable

"We're certifying under Part 29" is not a certification basis. The basis is the specific, negotiated set of regulations, amendment levels, special conditions, and equivalent-level-of-safety findings that apply to one aircraft — and for a novel configuration it does not exist until applicant and regulator build it together. The AW609 demonstrated how demanding this is: with no tiltrotor category in the regulations, its basis was assembled from Part 29 plus special conditions covering conversion modes, proprotor dynamics, and failure states the rules never imagined — an effort still under way two decades on. Powered-lift teams are living the same story. The programs that move draft the basis early, argue it with data, and revise it as the design matures. The programs that stall treat it as paperwork for later.

3. Put loads before everything

Most early-program structural problems are loads problems. Bad loads propagate silently — wrong loads produce wrong margins, wrong margins produce wrong structure, and the error surfaces only when the flight loads survey turns the margin map red. For powered lift the exposure is worse, because the sizing cases live in the flight regime that makes the aircraft novel: transition-corridor maneuvers, motor-out in hover, gusts during conversion. Neither fixed-wing nor helicopter intuition finds them. Three actions are cheap early and brutal to skip: a V-n and maneuver envelope for every flight mode including transition; a preliminary external loads model covering the full envelope, even rough; and a versioned loads-to-stress handoff so no analysis runs against stale numbers.

4. Price inspection intervals as product economics

Damage tolerance substantiation sets inspection thresholds and repeat intervals — and those intervals become an operating cost for every customer, on every aircraft, for the life of the fleet. Operators comparison-shop direct maintenance cost per flight hour the way designers comparison-shop fuel burn. The lever exists only early: design for inspectability, choose materials and working stress levels with growth life in mind, and scope the test program to support the intervals the business needs to publish. By the time the Airworthiness Limitations Section is written, those decisions are years old and the ALS merely documents their consequences. F&DT is a product economics function wearing a compliance badge — which is the business case for seating F&DT engineers in preliminary design reviews, not just

certification reviews.

5. Treat special conditions as a negotiation, not a sentence

When the FAA issues special conditions for a novel aircraft, some teams comply as written, however expensive. Others recognize the special condition for what it is: the opening position in. co14rsa8eC negotiation about how safety gets demonstrated for an aircraft the regulations never anticipated. Means of compliance, applicable amendment levels, ELOS findings, and the balance between test and analysis are all discussable — if the applicant arrives with engineering substance. The regulator's interest is a defensible safety case, not an expensive one. The constraint is time: leverage exists only until hardware and test plans commit to an interpretation. The negotiation window closes the day you cut metal.

The Common Thread

Each principle is a version of the same observation: fatigue and damage tolerance outcomes are set at preliminary design and merely documented at certification. The material choices, working stress levels, inspection concepts, and structural architecture that determine whether a hybrid airframe certifies affordably are locked in years before the first compliance report — which is why F&DT belongs in the preliminary design review, seated next to loads and configuration, not waiting at the end of the program for something to check.

For a hybrid eVTOL structure, that early seat carries a specific obligation: a written F&DT plan that covers both §29.571 and §29.573 substantiation paths — and explains, joint by joint, how they interface. Programs that can produce that plan at PDR hold negotiating leverage with the regulator, credible interval economics for their operators, and a structures schedule that stays off the critical path. Programs that cannot are carrying their highest-risk item unpriced.

About the Author

David Gambill is the founder of GnG Aero Consulting and a structures and certification engineer with more than thirty years across rotorcraft, tiltrotor, fixed-wing, and eVTOL programs. His career spans eight years on CH-47 Chinook structures and over a decade on Boeing's 777, 767, and 787 fixed-wing programs, Design Quality leadership on the AW609 civil tiltrotor at AgustaWestland (Leonardo), and chief-engineer roles at eVTOL and hybrid-VTOL startups including Vs at.Aircraft, tiDoroniero Cansceand